

Features

Before you choose to purchase a device like this, you need to decide whether your primary use for the device would be for listening to music or for portable data storage, or a mix of both. Most users opt for a combination of both. In this case, a minimum of 128 MB of memory will be required.

The players we received had memory capacities that varied from 128 MB to 256 MB. Higher-memory versions are also available. A 128 MB MP3 player can easily fit in 15 to 18 songs—this translates to around an hour of music. The MP3 players from ACi, MSI, Transcend, Sony, Samsung and Creative have 256 MB of storage space.

Any generic portable audio solution will perform all the functions that an MP3 player should. However, if an MP3 player could provide us with more useful features, that would be more value for money. The Umax Vega, Apacer AudioSteno AP510 and the Sony Network Walkman all feature memory card readers.

The upside to this feature is that you can not only store data onto a memory card that can be read by the player, but also play songs off it. The Apacer Audio Steno AP510 and the Network Walkman both feature docking stations, which come in handy while charging the players, as well as while transferring data onto the player at the same time.

Another interesting feature of the Apacer Audio Steno AP510 docking station is the stereo speakers. The catch is, you can only use the stereo speakers when the docking station is connected to the PC; besides, the speakers are quite tinny—you'd be better off with the bundled earphones.

The ACi Truly MP-301 stood out as a one-of-its-kind MP3 player. It is small, sleek device that offers a 65K colour DST display. You can view photos on it, read text files and also listen to music—all at the same time.

The Creative Rhomba NX, on the other hand, has a feature that will find favour with users who like to listen to FM. It has a built-in FM sensitivity option that lets you adjust the signal strength reception of the FM tuner.

The downside is that the player drains more juice from the battery if this feature is turned on.

For those who like to use portable digital audio players as a storage option as well, the



Ennyah Digisound II

Creative MuVo NX and TX, the Apacer AV 220 and the Transcend 256 MB let you use the device as portable storage without a battery. If you want to listen to MP3s, just connect the memory stick to the MP3 dock (which needs a battery), and voilà, you have an MP3 player! The Transcend is more of a memory stick, with all the controls built on the same unit, but it too requires a battery to function as an MP3 player.

Another unique portable audio player was the Samsung Yepp Sports YP-60, which is targeted towards those whose lifestyle includes regular sporting activities. In fact, this player will find favour with those who are health conscious, since it is the only one that features a heart beat rate monitor and a calorie counter.

Other features that we found particularly useful included the Line-in encoding option on the Creative Rhomba NX, S-Media and the Samsung models.

This is helpful since your old Walkman with a cassette tape can be directly connected to the MP3 player, and the tape can be converted to MP3s using the Line-in encoding option. You can connect an external tape deck instead of a Walkman, or a microphone source, or an external FM tuner (if your player doesn't have one).

Customisable equalisers are a must in MP3 players. Most players only offered presets; some, such as the Sony, Samsung, Creative, ACi and S-Media, offered customisable equalisers.

Voice recording and FM recording were other features that some MP3 players came equipped with, and this adds to the versatility of the player.

None of the players, except the Sony Network Walkman and the Apacer AV220, supported voice recording. The FM recording feature, on the other hand, was a mixed bag: 12 out of the 21 players supported this feature.

Ergonomics And Ease Of Use

Ideally, a portable digital music player should be usable by any user—like a Walkman—apart from any advanced things that it does. Clearly marked, intuitively placed buttons make the experience worthwhile, not to mention the interface.

The Apacer AP510 had an excellent 3-line OLED display, while the ACi was in a league of its own with an icon-based display that lets you access all the features. The S-Media Butterfly has a very good interface, not to mention the sound quality, but the buttons are way too small.

The BenQ Joybee 120 had a single line LCD display, which was completely below par, and for most parts did not serve any purpose. The Samsung Yepp YP-T5 is an tiny player that will definitely appeal to women. It is the only player featuring a joystick-based controller for accessing menus, skipping tracks and volume control.

The interface here is very intuitive, and you can start right from the word go. The only issue is that the joystick is fairly small given the size of the player, and will be irritating to users with large fingers.

Build quality is another important factor, and the Umax Draco was bad in this department. The battery cover of this device is small and extremely

Syncing Lyrics On Your Portable Player

Listening to songs on a portable player is fun, but if you could display the lyrics for a song on the player, it would be absolutely fantastic! Players such as the Orite Music Cookie and the DMS MP301 player can let you do that.

Here's how you go about getting the lyrics for your songs. You can either play a song and search for the lyrics using a search engine using the song name as the keyword. Or, you can install a nifty little freeware called EvillLyrics, which displays the lyrics for the song as you play it on Winamp or Media player. You can then save the lyrics to a text file, and using the software bundled with the portable player, sync the lyrics to the player.



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